India's Strategic Autonomy

The Quad, BRICS, Russia, and the World's Most Consequential Non-Alignment

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Executive Summary

India's emergence as a global geopolitical actor in the 2020s represents the most significant shift in the Asian balance of power since China's accession to the WTO in 2001. India — the world's most populous nation (1.44 billion), its fifth-largest economy ($4 trillion GDP), and a nuclear-armed state with both a permanent seat aspiration at the UN Security Council and a growing military that is now the world's fourth-largest defense spender — is pursuing what New Delhi describes as "strategic autonomy": the capacity to advance India's national interests across great power divides without becoming subordinated to any single power's agenda. The 2020s have tested this posture with unusual severity: the US-China rivalry demands sides; Russia's Ukraine invasion forced an uncomfortable position; and China's border aggression has made the non-alignment equation more complex than it was during Nehru's Cold War founding of the Non-Aligned Movement.

India's geopolitical positioning is simultaneously a member of the US-led Quad (Quadrilateral Security Dialogue with the US, Japan, Australia); an active participant in the Russia-China-led SCO (Shanghai Cooperation Organisation); a founding member of the expanding BRICS bloc (now 10+ members); and a country that continues buying Russian arms and oil while condemning Russia's Ukraine invasion in non-aligned diplomatic language at the UN. This multi-vector positioning is not hypocrisy — it reflects a genuine strategic calculation that India's interests are best served by maintaining access across geopolitical divides while building enough autonomous capability that it is not dependent on any single patron.

Part I — The Quad: India's Indo-Pacific Security Architecture

The Quad's Resurrection and Significance

The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue — originally convened in 2007 between the US, Japan, Australia, and India following Indian Ocean tsunami relief operations — was dormant until 2017, then revived at the ambassadorial level in 2017 and elevated to Leaders' Summit level in March 2021. The Quad represents the most significant multilateral security framework India has joined — not a formal alliance (no mutual defense commitment, no Article 5 equivalent), but a structured mechanism for maritime security cooperation, intelligence sharing, technology partnership, and the visible projection of a "free and open Indo-Pacific" counter-narrative to Chinese influence.

For India, the Quad's value is primarily in:

1. Technology access: The iCET (Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies) US-India bilateral framework (launched January 2023) provides India access to US defense technology, joint production of jet engines (GE F414 for LCA Tejas), semiconductor cooperation, and space domain sharing that was previously inaccessible due to India's non-aligned status and ITAR (International Traffic in Arms Regulations) restrictions.

2. Maritime balance: India's Andaman and Nicobar Islands — at the mouth of the Malacca Strait — give India (and by extension the Quad) potential operational significance in any PLAN interdiction scenario in the Indo-Pacific. The Quad's maritime awareness exercises (Malabar naval exercise, PASSEX) build the interoperability that makes this significance real.

3. Diplomatic legitimacy: Quad membership signals to Southeast Asian nations that India is a security provider, not merely a security consumer — shifting India's regional role from "strategic partner of everyone" to a genuine contributor to regional order.

India's Quad Constraints

India's Quad participation has explicit limits that reflect the enduring logic of strategic autonomy. India has not endorsed AUKUS (the nuclear submarine transfer mechanism for Australia) — the provision of nuclear propulsion technology to a non-nuclear state is something India, as a non-NPT nuclear state that jealously guards its own nuclear programme, cannot fully endorse. India has not agreed to base US military assets on Indian territory, nor has it signed a bilateral defense treaty committing to US military support. The Quad remains a mechanism of convergence, not an alliance — India will cooperate where interests align and maintain freedom of action where they diverge.

Part II — BRICS: The Non-Western Pole

BRICS Expansion and India's Role

The 2023 BRICS Leaders' Summit in Johannesburg produced the most significant expansion of the bloc since its founding: Saudi Arabia, Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia, Argentina, and the UAE were invited to join, with most accepting (Argentina ultimately declined under Milei). The expanded BRICS — now representing approximately 45% of world population, 37% of global GDP (PPP), and a majority of global energy production — has become China's primary vehicle for building a non-Western institutional alternative to the US-led order. India's position within this expanded BRICS is complex: India is the only democratic member of BRICS+ (with South Africa), the only member with territorial disputes with China (the dominant partner), and the member most ambivalent about the anti-dollar and anti-Western dimensions of the bloc's agenda.

India's BRICS motivation is not anti-Westernism but market access — BRICS countries represent enormous trade and investment opportunities, and India's multilateral presence in the bloc ensures it has a voice in norm-setting for the Global South rather than leaving that space to China alone. India's nuanced position: support for BRICS as an economic forum for developing countries, resistance to BRICS becoming an anti-Western political bloc or a Chinese-dominated alternative financial architecture.

The De-Dollarisation Debate

One of BRICS's most contentious agendas is reducing dependence on the US dollar in international trade — replacing dollar settlement with bilateral currency arrangements, basket-of-currencies trade settlements, and ultimately a new BRICS currency. India's position: genuinely sympathetic to the goal (India experienced the "dollar weaponisation" risk through the SWIFT sanctions on Iran, a country it trades with extensively) but sceptical of the Chinese yuan becoming the replacement currency (that would simply swap dollar dependency for renminbi dependency, with worse geopolitical implications). India has actively promoted Indian rupee trade settlement — with Russia (for oil imports) and UAE (for bilateral trade) — as a practical interim step that serves Indian interests without either dollar or yuan dominance.

Part III — India-China: The Defining Bilateral

The LAC as the Structural Constraint

India's relationship with China — the defining bilateral for India's strategic future — was irrevocably altered by the Galwan Valley clash of June 2020. The two countries that had built a framework of "peaceful coexistence" while maintaining trade dependence ($125+ billion bilateral trade in FY2023) and unresolved border disputes found that the fiction of managed coexistence had limits. China's construction of military infrastructure along the LAC in Ladakh, its aggressive patrol activity in the eastern sector, and its demonstrated willingness to use lethal force in border confrontations made India's strategic community reassess the relationship structurally rather than tactically.

The bilateral disengagement process — conducted through Corps Commander-level military talks — has produced partial withdrawals from friction points (Galwan, Gogra, Hot Springs) while China maintains infrastructure build-up in Depsang Plains and Demchok that India views as threatening forward positions. As of August 2026, the LAC remains a managed but unresolved tension — periodically triggering diplomatic crises, never fully normalised.

Economic Decoupling — Partial and Painful

India's response to China's LAC aggression included deliberate economic decoupling measures: banning Chinese apps (267 banned by 2023), restricting Chinese FDI (mandatory government approval for any investment from China border-sharing countries), and attempting to reduce import dependence on Chinese-origin goods. The paradox: India's import dependence on China has increased despite these measures — bilateral trade reached a record $120 billion+ in FY2024, with a $85+ billion trade deficit as India imports electronic components, chemicals, and manufactured goods from China that it cannot yet source domestically or from alternative suppliers at equivalent cost. Full decoupling from China is economically damaging for India at its current stage of development; the PLI manufacturing programme is precisely the instrument designed to reduce this dependency over the medium term.

Part IV — India-Russia: The Oil Paradox

Buying Russian Oil While Opposing the War

Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 placed India in a diplomatically uncomfortable position: a Quad partner, deeply opposed to the principle of territorial conquest, but also a major buyer of Russian arms (approximately 65% of India's legacy military equipment is Russian-origin) and suddenly — after Western sanctions made Russian oil cheap — a major buyer of discounted Russian crude. India abstained on UN General Assembly resolutions condemning the Russian invasion, refused to join Western sanctions, and increased Russian oil imports from approximately 2-3% of Indian crude imports to approximately 35-40% by FY2024, purchasing at $15-25/barrel discounts to international benchmark prices.

India's rationale, consistently stated by Foreign Minister Jaishankar: "Europe buys Russian gas to survive the winter; India buys Russian oil to sustain its economy. No one in Europe told us to sacrifice our energy security for their political position." The honest assessment: India's Russian oil import surge has saved approximately $8-12 billion annually in energy costs — real fiscal space for a developing economy. It has also made India a de facto pressure relief valve for Russia's sanctioned energy exports, which China's MEA has noted approvingly and the US State Department has noted with restrained disapproval.

The Arms Dependency Transition

Russia's arms supply to India — already strained before Ukraine by delayed deliveries (Vikramaditya aircraft carrier, INS Chakra submarine, T-90 tank upgrades) — has become structurally unreliable since 2022. Russia's own war consumption of arms and munitions, combined with Western component sanctions on Russian defense production, has made new Russian arms deliveries to India uncertain and existing equipment difficult to maintain with spare parts. India is accelerating diversification: Rafale fighters from France, C-295 transport aircraft from Airbus (assembled in India), P-8I maritime patrol aircraft from Boeing, and Apache attack helicopters from the US are displacing Russian platforms in new procurements. The S-400 system — India's most high-profile Russian purchase, delivered 2021-2023 — remains a point of US concern (CAATSA sanctions risk) that India has so far successfully managed through diplomatic engagement.

Conclusion: The Architecture of Strategic Autonomy

India's Non-Alignment 2.0 is not neutrality — it is active multi-vector engagement that seeks to extract value from every major relationship while avoiding subordination to any. The Quad provides technology and maritime security; BRICS provides Global South legitimacy and market access; Russia provides cheap energy and legacy arms maintenance; the US provides technology, investment, and Indo-Pacific alignment; China is the primary threat and largest trade partner simultaneously. This portfolio approach to geopolitics would collapse under the weight of its contradictions if India were a small state — but India's scale (world's most populous nation, 4th-largest military spender, 5th-largest economy) gives it enough strategic weight to sustain it.

The defining test of the coming decade: whether India's growth trajectory (7% annually would make India the world's 3rd largest economy by 2035) delivers the autonomous capability base — in defense manufacturing, semiconductor supply chains, space assets, and diplomatic network — that transforms strategic autonomy from a posture into a structural reality. India in 2026 is closer to that structural reality than at any point in its post-independence history.

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All data from MEA, SIPRI, RAND, Carnegie India, Lowy Institute, and cited sources.